



LOOKING BACK: (from left) Kanwar Pal, Zaffarwal, Bittu and Mohkam Singh at the Golden Temple

GURCHARAN SINGH TOHRA, SGPC, 1984

"If the Centre continues its high-handedness, every Sikh will have to become a Bhindranwale."

fundamentalism spearheaded by the preacher-turned-militant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale, and the insidious support of militant groups from a hostile neighbour. While the pro-Khalistan agitation got only a ripple of support amidst the Sikhs in the country, it found resonance in a section of their diaspora.

The watershed was the 1984 Operation Bluestar, codename for the army action at the Golden Temple, and the anti-Sikh riots following Indira Gandhi's assassination, defining events that stoked a debilitating phase of terrorism, driven more by a paroxysm of revenge than separatist ideological underpinnings. Not surprisingly, terrorism lost sooner than expected. By the early '90s, public sentiment turned against pro-Khalistan terrorists who ruled the state with a gun. In mid-1992, when Punjab had its first elected government after five years of President's rule, terrorists were neutralised in a no-holds-barred police offensive. By 1993, terrorism was vanquished.

"It was not a premeditated movement but thrust

on us," says Wassan Singh Zaffarwal, the once-dreaded chief of the Khalistan Commando Force. One of the five-member Panthic Committee that made the Declaration of Khalistan on April 29, 1986, he surrendered in 2001. "If Bluestar had not happened, there would have been no bloodshed. We were used by Pakistan to keep the pot boiling." Others like Daljit Singh Bittu, a top ideologue and once underground member of the Panthic Committee, and Kanwar Pal Singh, former Babbar Khalsa militant, still swear by their Khalistan dream. "The militant movement was hijacked by criminals and we had no control over them" says Bittu, 45, who now leads a radical splinter Akali faction. Mohkam Singh, a one-time pro-militant ideologue and a long-time leader of Damdami Taksal says, "The violence-weary Sikh community wanted hardliners to take the democratic route and fight for their grievances but we, the radicals, failed to do that." Adds Kanwar Pal Singh, "We have learnt our lessons." In fact, everyone in Punjab has. ■